

Build Steps

1 Create Your Agent

Open Agent Builder and select Create new agent, then configure:

Agent Name	Finance & Budget Assistant
Description	Helps finance partners and cost centre owners review budget, actuals, variances, and year-end forecast.
Tone	Professional, precise, concise

2 Add the Data

Go to Knowledge and upload the provided Excel file (Finance_Budget_Data.xlsx). This file contains:

- Cost centre details (cost centre code, department, category, owner)
- Financial data (budget, actual, variance amount and percentage)
- Status (On Track, Over Budget, Under Budget)
- Forecast (full-year projection and commentary)

This is the only data the agent should use.

3 Add Agent Instructions

Paste the following into the Instructions / System guidance box:

You are a Finance & Budget Assistant supporting finance business partners and cost centre owners. Use the uploaded spreadsheet as your single source of truth.

When answering questions:

- Base all answers strictly on the data in the file
- If totals, variance percentages, or roll-ups are requested, calculate them from the rows
- Show supporting details where relevant (Cost Centre, Department, Category, Owner, Budget, Actual, Variance, Forecast, Commentary)
- Highlight cost centres that are Over Budget clearly
- Keep responses clear, professional, and concise

If a question cannot be answered from the data, explain what information is missing.

4 Add Suggested Prompts

Add these as Suggested Questions so users can click them:

Which cost centres are currently Over Budget and by how much?

Show total budget vs actual by department for this quarter

Top 5 variances in absolute euro value with commentary

Try These Live

Use these queries during the build-along to test your agent.

Variance & Status

List all cost centres with status Over Budget, sorted by variance %.
What is the largest favourable variance, and what's driving it?

Department Roll-ups

Show total budget, actual, and variance by department.
Which department has the highest forecast year-end spend?

Forecast View

Sum forecast year-end spend across all cost centres.
Compare full-year forecast vs current actual run-rate by department.

Insight Summary

Give me three financial risks or opportunities from this data.

How to Think About This Agent

This agent replaces:

- Manual variance review in Excel
- Repeated pivot table refreshes
- Re-cutting numbers for exec decks

With:

- ✓ Natural language finance questions
- ✓ Answers grounded in budget data
- ✓ Faster, more confident review meetings

This is trusted, internal AI — not generic chat.

Tip for real-world use

In a real deployment, cost centre owners would see only their own cost centres and finance leads would see their assigned business units, with live ERP data and approval thresholds applied. Today's session focuses on capability and pattern.

You've built an agent ✓

You now have an AI agent that can:

- Understand budget data
- Answer variance and forecast questions
- Surface spend risk and savings
- Support better, faster review meetings